

Chapter 142 - Dancing

Elder Pingyao's reproachful words were blocked back. Although she was still finding it hard to bear, since Chu Qingqiu had spoken, she couldn't say anything more.

Ning Fuyi winked at Elder Pingyao and held Chu Qingqiu even tighter, even reaching out to smooth her hair.

Elder Pingyao thus took several breaths, suppressing her irritation, and continued to ignore Ning Fuyi: "Sect Leader Tang wants us to prepare for the worst. If we truly can't find a way to extinguish the Infinite Ghost Fire in the end, we can only gather all the immortal sects and fight Penglai Realm to the death."

"Good," Chu Qingqiu said.

Watching their departing figures, Elder Pingyao stood with furrowed brows, sighing deeply. She could see the changes in Chu Qingqiu since her resurrection—compared to the past, she had much more human warmth.

These changes were obviously related to Ning Fuyi. When she first heard about the relationship between Divine Venerable Chu Ling and Ning Fuyi, she was truly shocked for several days and was only now slowly adapting.

The Chief Elder came down from the nearby steps tremblingly, his cloudy eyes looking toward the closed hall doors as he smiled slowly.

"Can you also see that the Divine Venerable has become unlike the Divine Venerable since her resurrection?" The Chief Elder hobbled to her side and sighed. "Back then, I thought the relationship between the Divine Venerable and that girl Ning Changfeng was unfathomable, but I never expected..."

Elder Pingyao nodded silently, her brows still furrowed.

"These decades haven't only seen changes in the Divine Venerable—Ning Fuyi has also changed. Every time I hear about what she's done, I find it incredible," Elder Pingyao shook her head. "But her actions are still so willful, giving people headaches."

"You can't say that. This old man thinks that despite experiencing vicissitudes, her nature hasn't changed—it's truly rare," the Chief Elder laughed with a voice like a bellows.

"Perhaps," Elder Pingyao rubbed her muscles and bones, her face full of fatigue. These years, she had almost single-handedly supported Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate and was truly exhausted.

"I only hope this chaotic world ends soon and the realm returns to peace," Pingyao said.

At the same time, Ning Fuyi led Chu Qingqiu by the hand through the willows. She used one hand to block the willow branches on both sides of the path for Chu Qingqiu while saying: "After all these years, these trees still haven't been trimmed or transplanted. Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate truly doesn't bother with small details."

"Are you only realizing this now?" Chu Qingqiu lowered her eyes to avoid the branches and retorted.

Ning Fuyi pursed her lips and suddenly released her hand, so the dense hanging branches fell like a veil, completely obscuring Chu Qingqiu's face.

Chu Qingqiu made a sound of annoyance and was about to push away the branches when Ning Fuyi parted them with both hands and unexpectedly kissed her lips.

The willow leaves fell again, covering her expression like a bridal veil, and also concealing her face that had suddenly flushed red like hibiscus flowers.

Chu Qingqiu pushed her away slightly, then lightly flicked her fingers. A strong wind swept by, and those hanging willow branches all braided themselves into thick, long plaits like a girl's hair.

The woman with a slightly red face turned her head to avoid those "braids" and squeezed past Ning Fuyi with dignity.

Ning Fuyi was first shocked, then laughed, shaking her head as she followed Chu Qingqiu's steps, insisting on linking arms with her.

Several familiar disciples in sect robes approached them. Upon seeing the two, they immediately became uncomfortable, their hands and feet moving awkwardly.

The group hurriedly stopped, with the leader bowing: "Greetings to the Divine Venerable, greetings to..."

Someone behind poked him and whispered: "Greetings to what? By seniority, she's your junior sister!"

Seeing the leading disciple's face turn bright red, Chu Qingqiu kindly concluded: "Alright, go about your business."

"Yes, Divine Venerable!" The group fled as if granted amnesty, pulling each other as they ran away.

Ning Fuyi hugged Chu Qingqiu and laughed like a rooster crowing, earning an exasperated elbow from Chu Qingqiu: "I think you're doing this on purpose."

"This is just my nature—I wish the whole world knew," Ning Fuyi stared at her intently. "Doesn't the Divine Venerable want that?"

Chu Qingqiu's heartstrings leaped under her gaze, and she avoided eye contact: "I don't mind."

Ning Fuyi concealed the complex emotions in her phoenix eyes, curved her lips, and pretended to let go of her hand. But then her palm suddenly turned in a circle, grasping her in reverse as they slowly walked along the path.

"Your willful behavior isn't really a problem, but in the future, if you encounter someone stronger than you, you still need to be more cautious," she suddenly said.

Another group of disciples approached, also hurriedly bowing. Chu Qingqiu nodded lightly, and after they fled in panic, she continued speaking.

"Although your current strength is formidable and I no longer worry about you being bullied, the world is vast after all—you should still be careful where you need to be."

"Also..."

"Are you giving me your last words?" Ning Fuyi spoke up, the smile fading from her eyes.

Chu Qingqiu fell silent, her steps continuing but with a touch of uncertainty.

"I haven't eaten in the dining hall for a long time," Ning Fuyi seemed to sense her mood and changed the subject, raising her smile again as she pointed toward the verdant distance. "Will you accompany me?"

Chu Qingqiu looked at her smile and felt a sharp pain in her heart, then said yes.

The dining hall was still the same as decades ago—noisy and bustling, with tables and chairs neatly arranged in rows. Today's dishes were drawn on the walls with immortal energy, ink flowing and sparkling.

It was currently noon, and the dining hall was busy with people coming and going, mostly young disciples who hadn't yet achieved grain avoidance¹. Seeing Chu Qingqiu enter, they naturally panicked, all bowing with mouths full of oil while holding their rice bowls.

Ning Fuyi saw Chu Qingqiu's restraint and pulled her to find seats behind a screen, smiling as she fetched several dishes, seemingly oblivious to the surrounding gazes.

"Qiu'er, look, this 'Weary Birds Returning to the Forest'² is my favorite—crispy outside and tender inside. Try some," Ning Fuyi said, using chopsticks to tear off a piece and holding it near her mouth.

Chu Qingqiu opened her mouth to take it, but her nose wrinkled into several lines.

Seeing she wasn't chewing, Ning Fuyi quickly extended her hand to her lips: "If you don't like it, why did you take it? Spit it out quickly."

Chu Qingqiu had intended to get a handkerchief, but seeing Ning Fuyi so naturally extending her hand, she paused, then opened her mouth and spat the meat into her palm.

Her face couldn't help but redden as she pretended to drink tea.

Ning Fuyi didn't mind at all, then put the spat-out food aside and wiped her hands: "If you don't like something, just refuse it. Why do you eat whatever I give you?"

"You said you liked it, so I wanted to try," Chu Qingqiu said softly. The tea diluted the meaty taste in her mouth, making her feel better.

"It's also my fault—I knew you don't eat meat," Ning Fuyi put a large piece of meat in her mouth and said indistinctly.

"During those days in the mortal realm, I had gotten used to eating it, but after leaving the mortal body, I returned to normal."

Ning Fuyi smiled and stopped feeding her.

The dining hall was filled with mixed aromas and the clinking of bowls and chopsticks—certainly not quiet. But watching the woman eat, Chu Qingqiu's heart felt more peaceful than sitting alone in a secluded bamboo grove.

She even unconsciously raised her hand to wipe away a bit of oil that had accidentally stuck to the corner of Ning Fuyi's mouth.

Ning Fuyi's phoenix eyes lifted, and she smiled at her with charming beauty.

Such days were what Ning Fuyi had once eagerly anticipated—waking at dawn and resting at dusk, leisurely brewing tea when there was nothing to do. But now, though she was living in this reality, each dawn and dusk reminded her.

Reminded her what it meant to count the days while waiting—waiting for farewell.

After Ning Fuyi finished eating, the two left under everyone's gaze, stepping on the bright sunlight toward the palace walls layered with emerald green.

Years ago, when Chu Qingqiu executed Elder Yuanming, Tranquil Mountain Palace was completely destroyed. But after thirty years, new pavilions had risen from the ruins, and now no traces of the former destruction could be seen.

Someone cleaned it regularly, so upon entering, it felt like a lifetime had passed.

Ning Fuyi touched the corridors and rocks at the entrance, remembering how she had once racked her brains trying to anger Chu Qingqiu and escape her teachings, and couldn't help but smile.

What had Chu Qingqiu's feelings been back then?

As she thought this, she also asked it aloud. Chu Qingqiu, who was following behind her, blushed but didn't answer.

What feelings indeed? Being both grateful that she remembered nothing and frustrated that she remembered nothing, feeling secretly saddened whenever she showed disgust and treated her as an enemy.

Never daring to show even a fraction of her care, but in unnoticed corners, her gaze always fell on her.

"I wonder who renovated it—it's exactly the same as before," Ning Fuyi wandered nostalgically. When she reached the back garden and saw the flowers blooming luxuriantly, she suddenly turned around.

"Divine Venerable, can you dance?" Ning Fuyi asked.

Chu Qingqiu initially thought she meant martial arts, but then realized and answered truthfully: "No."

"What about sword dancing?" Ning Fuyi drew a sword and tossed it to Chu Qingqiu.

"I can try," Chu Qingqiu said with some difficulty.

The wind became fierce, the sword cutting through the air, dancing out sword flowers under the bright sun. The sky full of scattered silver was dazzling, and her pure white sleeves brushed past the scattered silver, also becoming tinged with gentle radiance.

That figure couldn't be called graceful, because Chu Qingqiu wasn't graceful by nature. She was sharp, tall, righteously imposing—a single sword could shatter sunlight.

Only when her snow-white wrists smoothly turned the sword hilt, and when her black hair swept past her high-bridged nose, could one see some gentleness.

Ning Fuyi watched. She couldn't play music, so she could only wave her hand to stir up wind, which carried down colorful flowers as accompaniment.

During the sword dance, Chu Qingqiu glanced at Ning Fuyi's expression, and her heart immediately melted like spring snow, filled with fine, fragmented heartache. So she waved her hand and threw down the sword, stepping on the wind to land before her.

"Yiyi..." she said gently, raising her hand to wipe away tears that had somehow fallen from Ning Fuyi's face.

But those tears couldn't be wiped away no matter what. She suddenly felt as if that sword had pierced her heart, the pain making her legs weak.

Ning Fuyi had been holding back her sadness all along. She understood Chu Qingqiu, so she didn't want their final days to be spent in grief. But now, the sweeter things were, the greater the pain in her heart.

She truly loved Chu Qingqiu so much—loved her enough to learn to hide her love, loved her enough to desperately try to understand everything she couldn't understand.

Chu Qingqiu drew her into her arms, comforting her again and again.

"Yiyi, your future days are still long. When the Six Realms are stable, you'll be able to do anything you want," Chu Qingqiu said, holding tight the trembling body in her embrace.

"If heaven and earth are destroyed, we'll have nothing," she said. "You must live well."

Ning Fuyi shook her head: "I know."

"But if you die..." she clutched Chu Qingqiu's clothes, "if you die, how can I live?"

¹ Grain avoidance (辟谷): A practice in Taoism where advanced cultivators no longer need to eat regular food

² Weary Birds Returning to the Forest (倦鸟归林): A poetic name for a dish, likely referring to roasted poultry